



FRANMUN 2026

Franciscan sisters' school

UNWOMEN committee: Research Report

Combating Child Marriage and Protecting the Rights and Well Being of Girls.



UNWomen

Definitions:

Child marriage: the marriage of girls before the age of 18, which is recognized as a human rights violation.

Minimum Age of Marriage: The legally established age in which individuals are permitted to marry. Implementing a minimum age of marriage is crucial in ending the legalization of child marriage.

Human Rights Violation: Child marriage is a violation of human rights, as it restricts girls' decision making, physical mobility and access to education and economic opportunities, and it increases their exposure to violence and health complications.

Empowerment of Girls: The process of empowering girls to have control over their lives, make informed decisions, and access opportunities for education, health, and economic involvement.

Early Pregnancy: A common consequence of child marriage, that leads to increase the risks of sexual and health complications for young girls.

Partner Violence: Child marriage is linked to a higher level of violence within marriage, hurting the physical and emotional safety of girls.

Educational damage: Child marriage often leads to reduce school opportunities for girls, that will limit their future life.

Poverty Cycle: Girls married before the age of 18 are more likely to earn less over their lifetime and live in poverty with their children.

Legal Reform: The process of changing laws and policies to prohibit child marriage and protect the rights of girls, often involving governments, civil society, and international organizations.

Third war countries: Third war countries are poor or undeveloped countries that go through crises and war, they are nations that often face high economic, financial and political challenges. War often destroys local economies, jobs and family properties, one of the few reasons underage marriages is often occurred in third war countries is because there are families facing extreme hunger or displacement often marry off their underaged daughters to either reduce household expenses or receive a “bride price” that helps the rest of the family survive

Background:

Marriage below the age of 18 is a human rights violation, it remains to be one of the biggest global issues today, it is a problem that affects cultures, traditions and ethnic groups.

Child marriage exists due to deep rooted reasons, such as poverty, gender inequality and sometimes gender norms.

In some places families see it as a way to protect their young girls or help with financial issues by selling their child off to marriage, or even having a belief that marriage brings security even though it often does the very opposite. In some communities, traditional and religious values normalize child marriage, and having poor birth registration systems and laws, can make it harder for governments to prevent it.

Child marriage can have serious effects on children such as the lack of education, increasing their risk of violence and exploitation, reducing their opportunities in the future and in some cases where they are forced to have children, it increases the odds of developing infections such as HIV and Aids.

Despite the efforts done by the governments to help eliminate child marriages, social, financial and economical struggles, especially in third-war countries where child marriage are most common, continue to make it difficult to prevent the practice.

Critical Events:

1.South Asia (India): India has the largest number of child marriages in absolute terms, with over 14 million women between 20 and 24 years old stating that they were married before the age of 18. Bangladesh is another country with large regional prevalence at 51%.

2. Nepal (2015 Earthquake): The devastating losses experienced in terms of property destruction and the loss of income by families caused a noticeable increase in marriages among those below the age of eighteen.

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3."Marry Your Rapist" Law Debate (November 2016) in Turkey:

Turkey's ruling party, the Justice and Development Party (AKP), put forth an incredibly controversial piece of legislation. This law would have either postponed or suspended sentencing for those men who were found guilty of sexually abusing children if the rape was "not conducted by force."

4.Escalation of Underage Marriages in Gaza (2025–2026):

Current humanitarian crises have presented very challenging circumstances for adolescent girls residing in areas affected by conflict. As per reports from the United Nations Population Fund (UNFPA), there is an alarming rise in cases of child marriages. The disintegration of social, legal, and healthcare security systems, along with extreme displacement and malnutrition, has put tremendous pressure on families, resulting in some of them marrying their children at a very tender age.

5.August 2021 - Taliban Takeover in Afghanistan:

The Taliban came back to power in Afghanistan in August 2021. There were many restrictions placed on girls' education and women's rights. The closing of secondary schools for girls limited education opportunities for girls, and there was an increased fear that more girls will get married at a younger age since there are not as many options for education and marriage.

Current situation:

There is a growing sense among governments and international bodies that child marriage is a serious human rights problem. Many leaders are now working hard to cut down and finally end child marriage. In countries the number of children's marriages has gone down thanks to tougher laws, more schooling and programmers that help and protect children. For example, the share of women aged 20 to 24 who were married before turning 18 fell from 25 % ten years to 21 % today. These actions have stopped 25 million child marriages in the last decade, and a big part of that success comes from progress in India.

Child marriage is still a big problem around the world. About 650 million girls and women today have been married before they turned 18. This tells us that while some progress has been made many children are still caught in child marriage. Child marriage is more common in places where poverty, inequality, insecurity and strong social pressure exist. In some countries laws are weak or not enforced. It remains hard to keep children from being married too early.

A big hurdle is that some families think child marriage can protect their children, ease money problems or keep family customs alive. Because of these laws alone cannot stop child marriage. Governments must also tackle the economic reasons that push families to arrange child marriages. That is why global governments and organizations need to keep working. They should make laws stronger, give children the chance to study, help families in poverty and tell people how harmful child marriage is. If we address both the reasons, for child marriage and its effects countries can do more to protect children. Finally, child marriage ends everywhere.

Treaties and Organizations:

Marriage Convention (1962):

The Marriage Convention (Convention on Consent to Marriage, Minimum Age for Marriage and Registration of Marriages)

is an international human rights treaty adopted by the United Nations General Assembly in 1962. It was established to protect individual freedom in marriage and eliminate practices like forced marriage and child marriage.

UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs - Target 5.3):

A global blueprint adopted by UN member states, Target 5.3, is directly related to girls' marriage, as adolescent girls are overwhelmingly the group most impacted by child, early, and forced marriage. setting a specific target to eliminate all harmful practices, including child, early, and forced marriage.

CEDAW:

The CEDAW (Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women) is an international legal instrument that requires countries to eliminate discrimination against women and girls in all areas and promotes women's and girls' equal rights. The Commission's work has been instrumental in bringing to light all the areas in which women are denied equality with men. These efforts for the advancement of women have resulted in several declarations and conventions, of which the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women is the central and most comprehensive document.

Convention on the Rights of the Child (CRC, 1989):

A widely ratified human rights treaty that defines a child as anyone under 18. It guarantees children rights to protection, health, education, and freedom from harmful practices.

UNICEF: Leading UN organization combating child marriage. They provide information, implement national strategies and empower women through education and health services.

Questions to consider:

1. What is your country's policy on Child Marriage?
2. Does your country currently have Child Marriage? If yes, what is the country doing to Protect the Rights and Well Being of Girls?
3. How does your country address Child Marriage and Protects the Rights and Well Being of Girls?
4. How receptive is your country's political process in protecting young girls by ending underage marriage and upholding their fundamental rights?
5. Which national events or political transitions have impacted underaged married women positively or negatively?
6. What long term strategies or reforms do your country propose to ensure sustained progress toward girls whose rights and futures are restored when underage marriage is ended?

Useful Resources:

<https://www.unwomen.org/en/news/stories/2012/10/un-women-approaches-to-end-child-marriage#:~:text=The%20right%20to%20'free%20and%20full'%20consent,an%20informed%20decision%20about%20a%20life%20partner.>

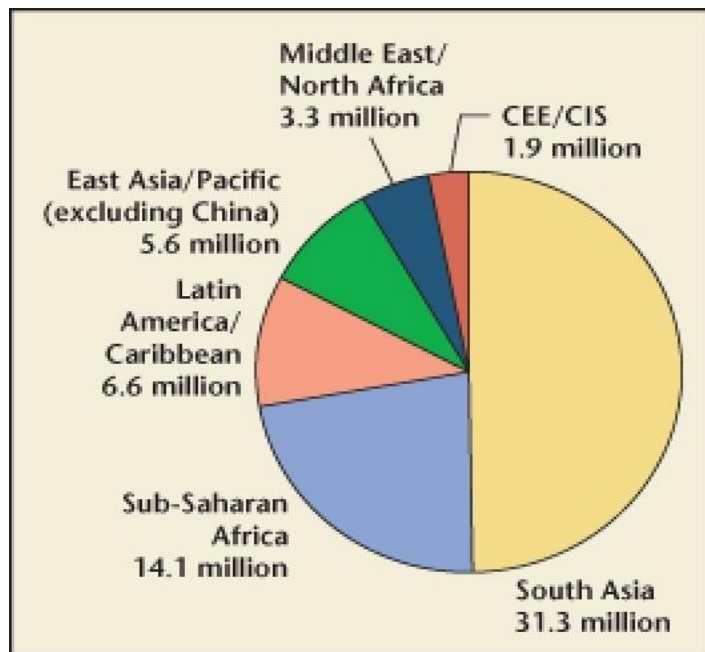
<https://www.ohchr.org/en/instruments-mechanisms/instruments/convention-consent-marriage-minimum-age-marriage-and>

https://www.unicef.org/protection/unfpa-unicef-global-programme-end-child-marriage#:~:text=Our%20response%20*%20In%202025%2C%20the%20Global,key%20strategy%20to%20effectively%20end%20child%20marriage.

https://aidmi.org/aidmi-and-the-sustainable-development-goals-sdgs-driving-local-action-to-achieve-global-goals/?gad_source=1&gad_campaignid=22384598107&gbraid=0AAAAAp90M15fmWe4M8ZMAppD46YMhiHZM&gclid=Cj0KCQjwkt_UBhDMARIsALpnOAwpOHfn1JzXgEkX8GcGxM7_U_gNZFFjAxx76pXOb4ycrJwdTOHEzfgaAnvPEALw_wcB

<https://www.unfpa.org/child-marriage#:~:text=Target%205.3%20of%20the%20goals%20is%20aimed,social%20norms%2C%20gender%20stereotypes%20and%20power%20relations.v>

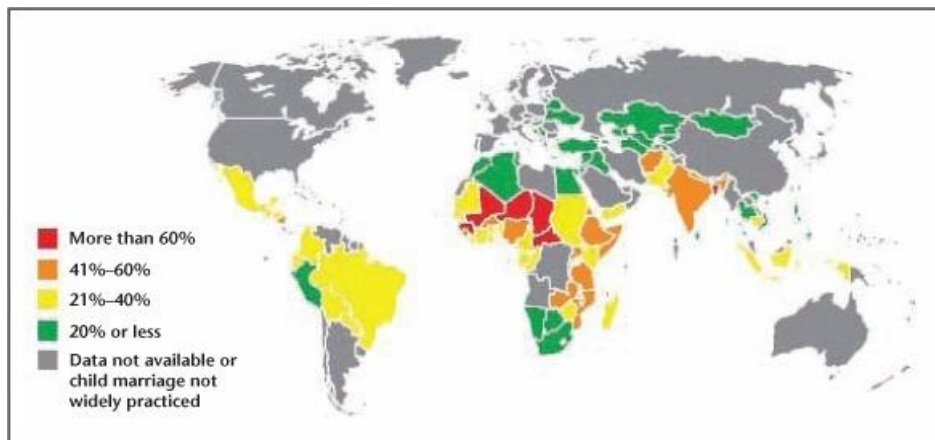
https://treaties.un.org/pages/viewdetails.aspx?src=treaty&mtdsg_no=xvi-3&chapter=16&clang=en#:~:text=CHAPTER%20XXIV.%20CHAPTER%20XXV.%20CHAPTER%20XXVI.%20CHAPTER,Signatories%20%3A%2016.%20Parties%20%3A%2056.%20Text.



Number of women aged 20–24 who were

married or in union before age 18, by region (2006). CEE/CIS, Central and Eastern Europe and the Commonwealth of Independent States. Reproduced with permission from United Nations Children's Fund. Progress for Children: A World Fit for Children Statistical Review. New York: UNICEF; 2007.

http://www.unicef.org/publications/files/Progress_for_Children_No_6_revised.pdf.



Percentage of women aged 20–24 who were married or in union before age 18 (1987–2006).
Reproduced with permission from United Nations Children’s Fund. Progress for Children: A
World Fit for Children Statistical Review. New York: UNICEF; 2007.
http://www.unicef.org/publications/files/Progress_for_Children_No_6_revised.pdf.